Queering place, adequating difference: A rapid and anonymous survey investigating neighborhood ideology in San Francisco

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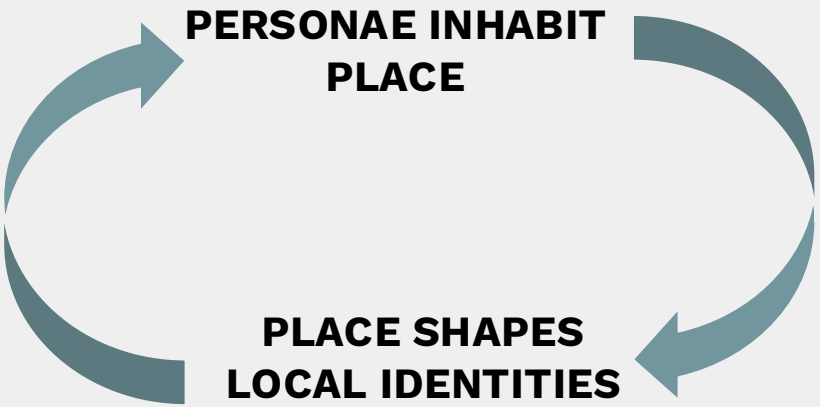


New Ways of Analyzing Variation 54
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Place and identity

Place is composed of
- a physical space
- the people who occupy it physically and symbolically

Place and identity are mutually reinforcing:



Tuan 1991; D'Onofrio 2020; King 2021

Constructing Place

We can also apply **adequation** and **distinction** to the construction of place

Neighborhood A:	Neighborhood B:	Neighborhood C:
Urban	Rural	Rural
Working Class	**Working Class**	Wealthy
Pred. Latino	**Pred. Latino**	Pred. Latino

Places can become categorically marked for sexuality

- The “gayborhood” or “gay ghetto” essentialized by (non-normative) sexuality
- Other areas typically unmarked w.r.t. (normative) sexuality

How is sexuality lexically characterized relative to other social dimensions that constitute place?

Bucholtz & Hall 2004, 2005; Gal & Irvine 2019; Ghaziani 2014

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Place identity does not exist in isolation

The **Castro**



The **Mission**



The **Marina**



Carmichael & Reed 2025



San Francisco Planning Department 2024

Quick, how would you describe _____ in one word?

What about _____?

Reworking the rapid anonymous survey

Goal: elicit ideologies about these three neighborhoods

Elicitation Sites

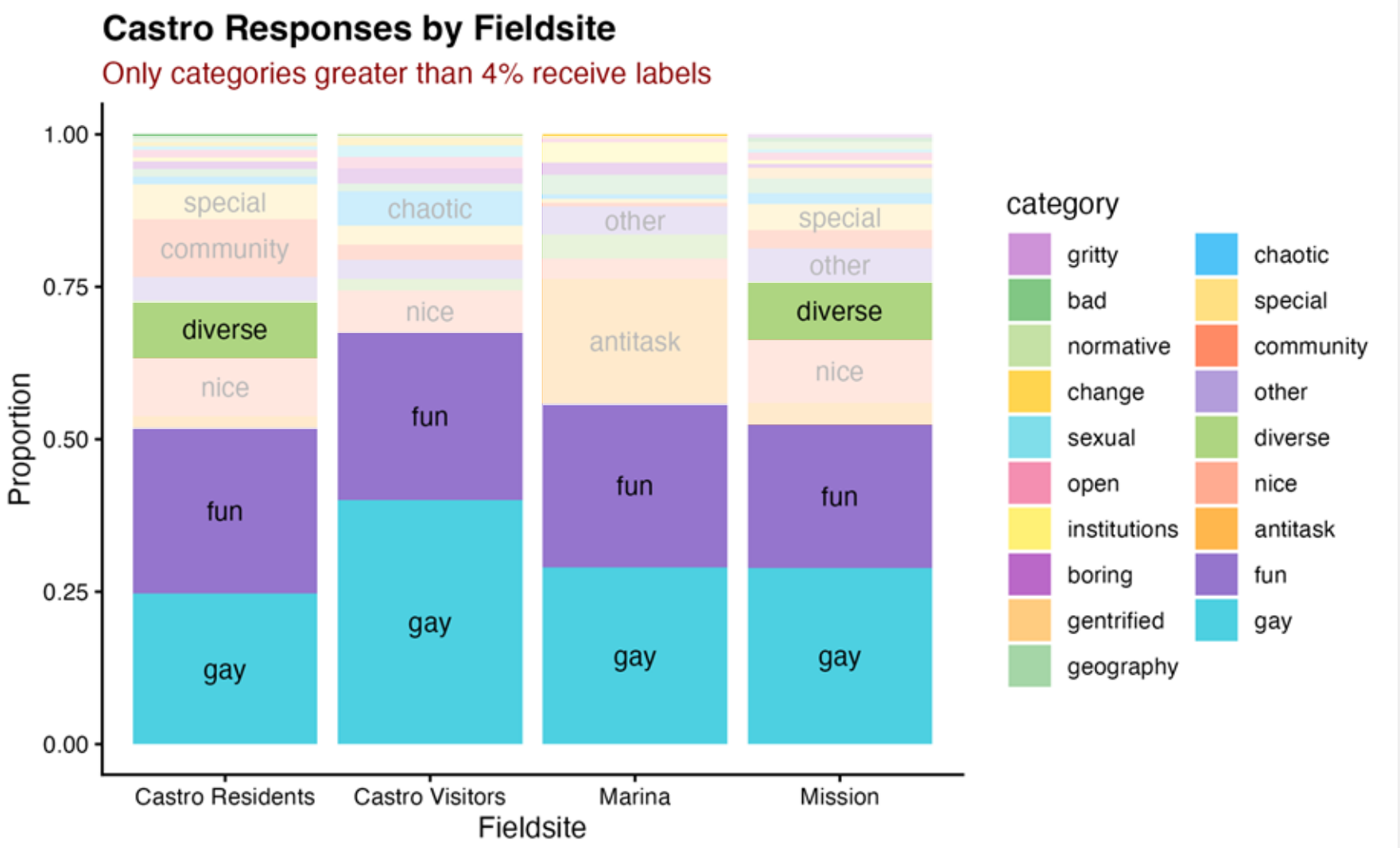
- **Castro** x 2 → **gay sexuality**
  - **Residents** on weekday afternoons
  - **Visitors** on weekend nights
- **Mission** → **diverse ethnicities**
- **Marina** → **normative sexuality**

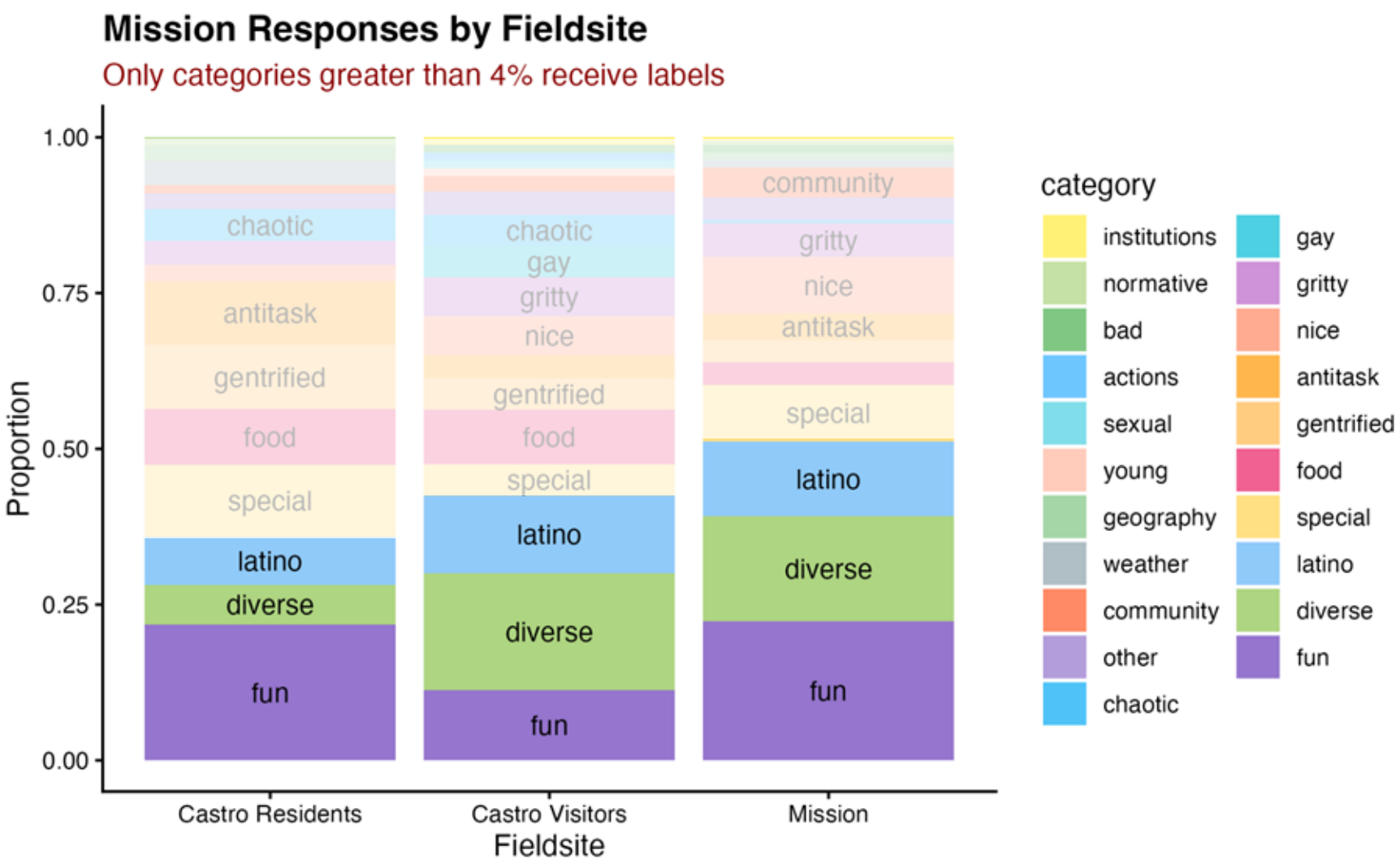
638 participants

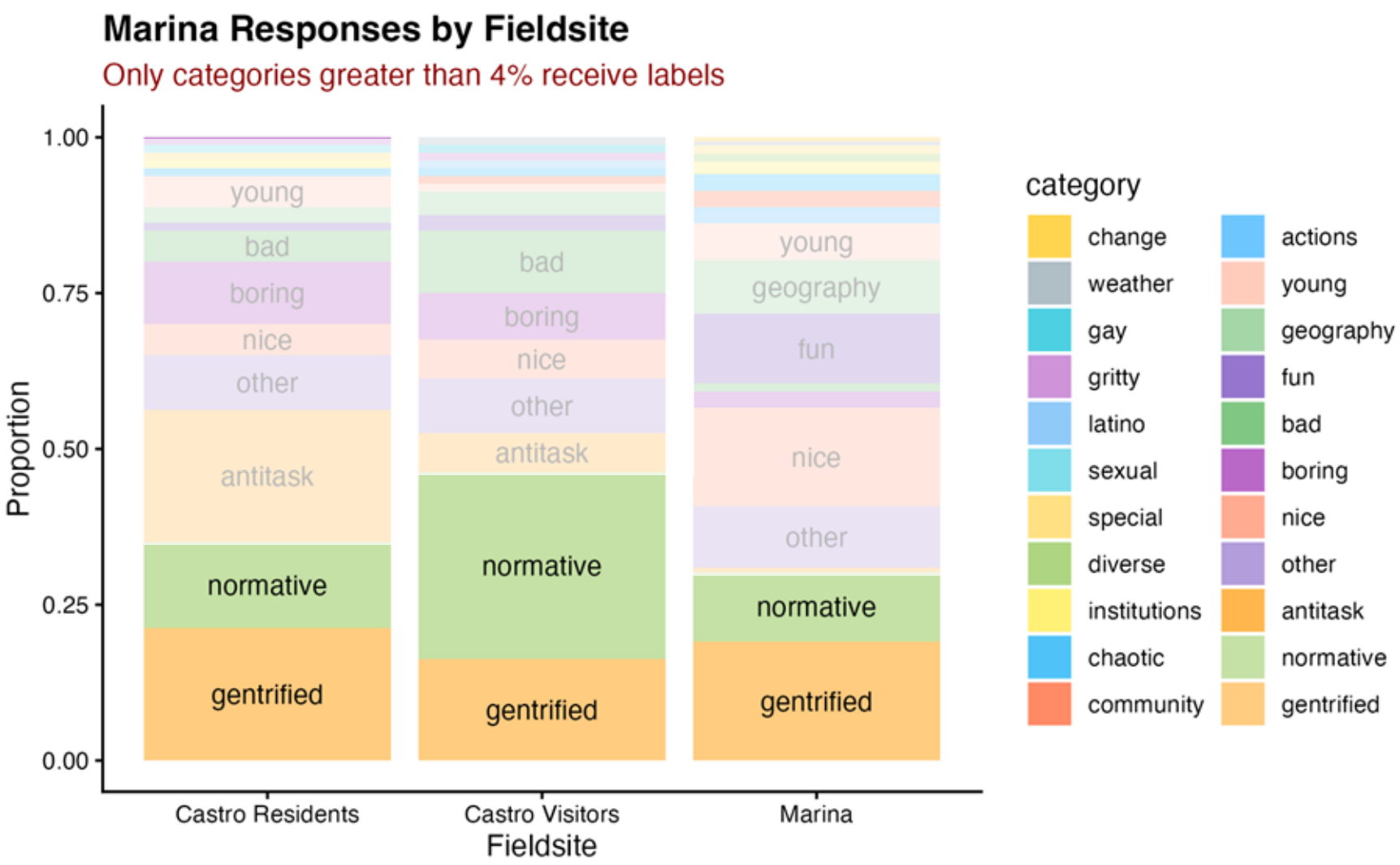
1276 responses

24 categories

Labov 1964; Braun & Clarke 2006


Castro Responses by Fieldsite
Only categories greater than 4% receive labels
Proportion
1.00
0.75
0.50
0.25
0.00
special
community
diverse
nice
fun
gay
chaotic
nice
fun
gay
other
antitask
fun
gay
special
other
diverse
nice
fun
gay
Castro Residents
Castro Visitors
Marina
Mission
Fieldsite
category
gritty
bad
normative
change
sexual
open
institutions
boring
gentrified
geography
chaotic
special
community
other
diverse
nice
antitask
fun
gay


Mission Responses by Fieldsite
Only categories greater than 4% receive labels
Proportion
1.00
0.75
0.50
0.25
0.00
chaotic
antitask
gentrified
food
special
latino
diverse
fun
chaotic
gay
gritty
nice
gentrified
food
special
latino
diverse
fun
community
gritty
nice
antitask
special
latino
diverse
fun
Castro Residents
Castro Visitors
Mission
Fieldsite
category
institutions
normative
bad
actions
sexual
young
geography
weather
community
other
chaotic
gay
gritty
nice
antitask
gentrified
food
special
latino
diverse
fun


Marina Responses by Fieldsite
Only categories greater than 4% receive labels
Proportion
1.00
0.75
0.50
0.25
0.00
young
bad
boring
nice
other
antitask
normative
gentrified
Castro Residents
Castro Visitors
Marina
Fieldsite
category
change
weather
gay
gritty
latino
sexual
special
diverse
institutions
chaotic
community
actions
young
geography
fun
bad
boring
nice
other
antitask
normative
gentrified

Participants describe the Marina as “straight” in 3.2% of responses...

But only when asked about the Castro first.

Lexical priming effects

Every participant produced two neighborhood characterizations

Second response implicitly invites comparison between neighborhoods

Forward probability = P(W2 | W1)
How does the first response predict the second response?

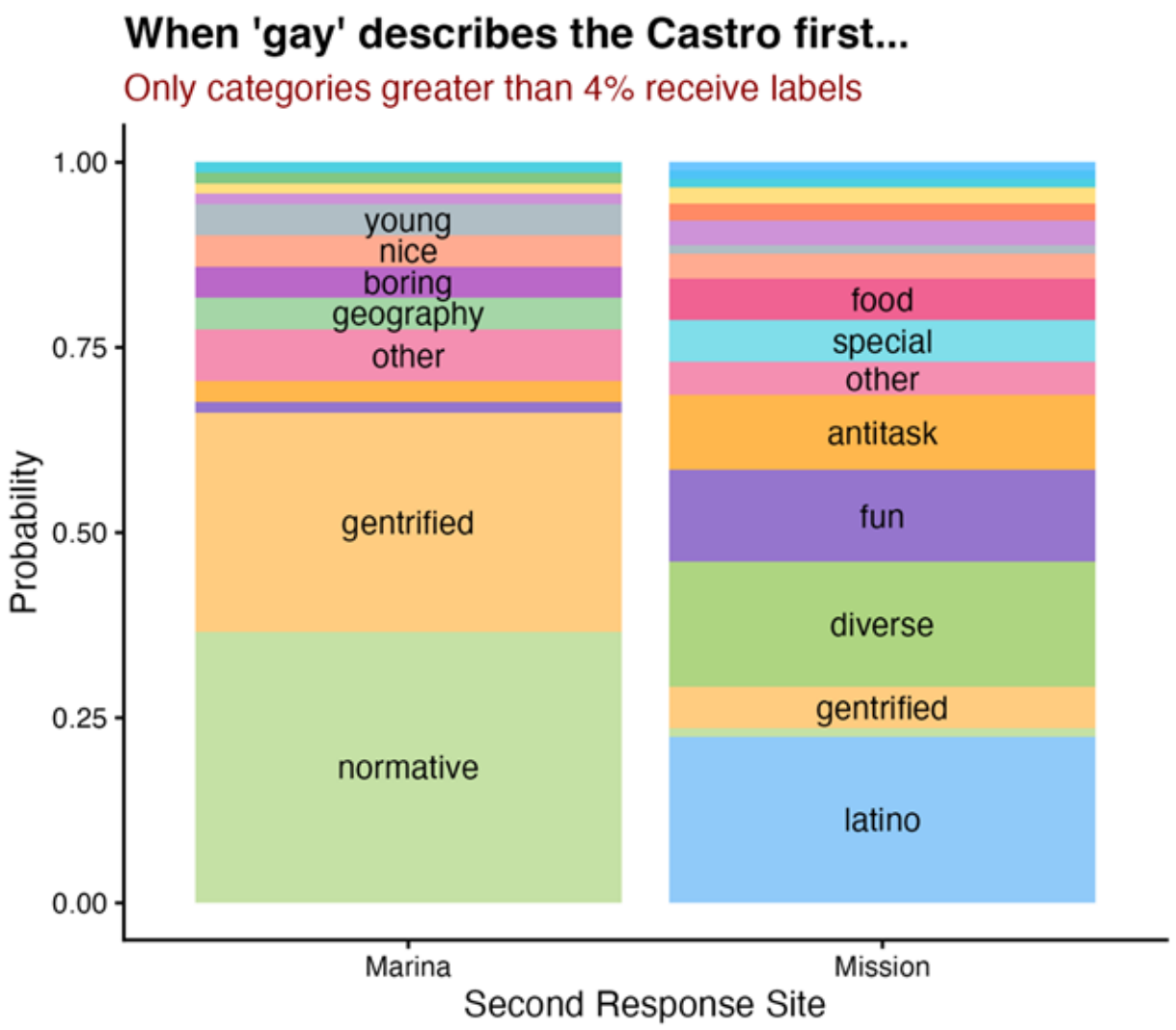


Quick! Describe "Response Site 1"!

[Response 1]

What about "Response Site 2"?

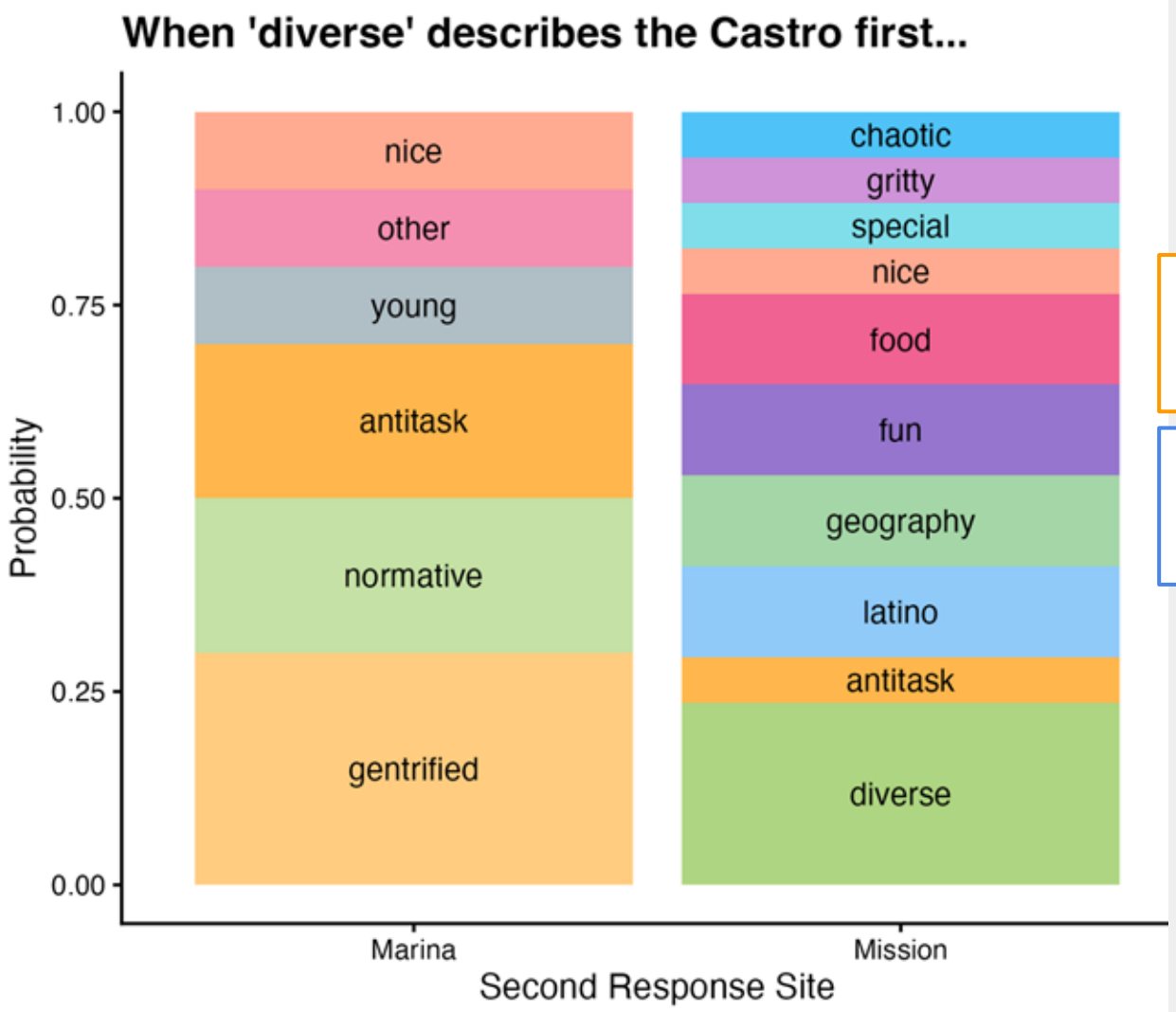
[Response 2]



Second Response

Mission: **latino** is more likely than expected

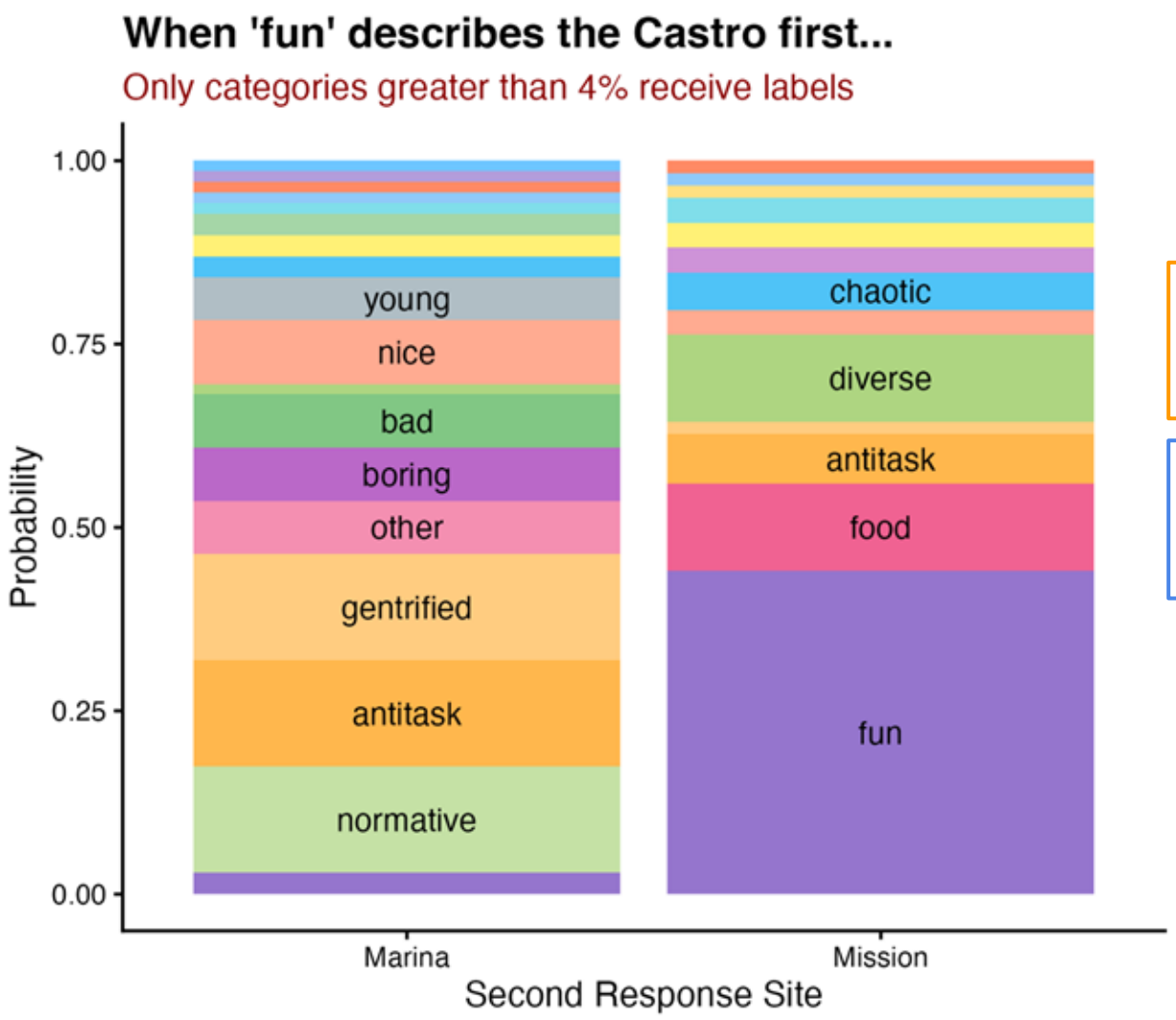
Marina: **normative** and **gentrified** more likely than expected



Second Response

Mission: **diverse** is more likely than expected

Marina: **gentrified** is more likely than expected



Second Response

Mission: **fun** is much more likely than expected

Marina: **fun** is slightly less likely than expected

Differentiation

About the <u>Castro</u> and <u>MARINA</u>

- If Castro is associated with **gay** or **diverse**, Marina is associated with **normative** and **gentrified**
- If Castro is associated with **fun** Marina is less likely to be described as such (not fun)

	Marina	
Castro First	Gay → Normative	

Adequation

About the <u>Castro</u> and the <u>MISSION</u>

- If Castro is associated with **gay** or **diverse**, Mission is associated with **diverse** and **latino**
- If Castro is associated with **fun**, Mission is associated with **fun**

	Marina	**Mission**
Castro First	Gay → Normative	Gay → Latino

Conclusion

The Marina is distinguished as normative

- Marked for normative sexuality through differentiation
- Neighborhoods ***can*** be marked for normative sexuality
- Via normative social dimensions that clash with non-normativity
  - Despite the Castro sharing in some of these dimensions

The Castro and the Mission are jointly constructed as diverse

- Through the adequation of non-normativity
- Via (non-normative) sexuality and (non-normative) ethnicity
  - Despite differences in other social dimensions

Social dimensions (race, **sexuality**, class, etc.) **are bundled together in service of local contrasts** (normativity)

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